

How Bridgerton Makes History [C1]

Nonostante non manchino gli elementi di fantasia e le reinterpretazioni, il ‘period drama’ più amato degli ultimi anni si affida ai consigli di un team di consulenti storici. Ogni scostamento dalla realtà è voluto, non casuale.



When the first season of the Netflix series *Bridgerton* premiered on Christmas Day, Amanda Vickery sat at home with her three daughters and watched every episode. This was in 2020, in the midst of England's lockdown, and Vickery remembers thinking, "[Thank goodness](#) for this escape." That Vickery could lose herself that way is a particular [compliment](#) to *Bridgerton*, an [enflowered](#) fantasy adapted from the Regency-set romance novels of Julia Quinn. Vickery, a professor at Queen Mary, University of London, is a historian. And *Bridgerton*, a show in which empowered women [swoon](#) to orchestral versions of Ariana Grande, takes a rather liberal approach to history. Watching at home, Vickery did not imagine that she would ever work on *Bridgerton*, but for the third season she served as its historical consultant, succeeding her friend and colleague, Hannah Greig, a Professor Emerita at Royal Holloway, University of London. Does a show that [repurposes](#) Coldplay's *Yellow* as a wedding march really require historians? Yes. Several. "We're aware that *Bridgerton* isn't aiming for documentary accuracy," Vickery said during a recent video call, with Greig in an adjoining window. "It is a fantasy, but it's a fantasy that's [grounded](#) in an understanding of period." Her role, as she sees it, is to point out potential anachronisms and then let the writers and directors decide from there. Greig had a slightly different formulation. "You are the [on-call geek](#), the walking encyclopaedia," she said. But she and Vickery share a [motto of sorts](#): The show makes choices, not mistakes. "When they do [depart](#) from the [absolute letter](#) of history, it's done [knowingly](#) and for a reason," Vickery said. "It's intentional." The Regency period is generally understood as [spanning](#) the years from the end of the 18th century to the accession of Queen Victoria in 1837, a period [conterminous](#) with Jane Austen's work and a popular setting for romance novels. While the *Bridgerton* writers are broadly aware of the manners and customs of the period, there is an assistant in the writers' room charged with googling questions (Were there [hot air balloons](#) in this period? Yes.) and offering historical [tidbits](#). There is also a dialogue consultant, John Mullan, another University College London professor. Mullan reviews each script and makes suggestions, helping, as the [showrunner](#), Jess Brownell, put it, to "[Regency-ify](#)" the [speech](#). World

I veri *Bridgerton*: le famiglie aristocratiche del Regno Unito Un viaggio nelle famiglie aristocratiche del Regno Unito durante l'epoca della Reggenza, per scoprire cosa c'è di vero nei *Bridgerton* e come prestigio, politica e ricchezza definivano le influenze nella società britannica. Julia Nigmatullina Brownell accepts nearly all of his notes, except when it would take ten Regency words to replace one modern one. "In that case," she said, "it's just not worth it." Greig and Vickery also review the scripts in advance. Sometimes they are asked to consult on larger questions, like: What was the social status of a [widow](#) in this period? The goal, Vickery said, is not to be "a [schoolmistress](#), [telling them off](#)," but instead to give the creative team whatever information they require and offer suggestions that might free them from a [plot hole](#). Of course, some anachronisms are deliberate. In this Regency it is forever springtime and it very rarely rains. As

Bridgerton is a progressive fantasy, it allows women significant autonomy and includes people of colour within the highest [echelons](#) of English society. “It is a way of [evening out the scales](#) for how much [erasure](#) there has been of people of colour in Regency times in television and in films,” Brownell said. Most notably, Bridgerton [cast](#) Golda Rosheuvel, a biracial actress, as Queen Charlotte. While at least one historian has [posited](#) the real Queen Charlotte as multiracial, that theory has found little acceptance. In the queen’s own time, Vickery noted, Charlotte was perceived as very German and very [dull](#). “Thankfully, this Queen Charlotte is much more exciting,” Vickery said. So exciting that she has inspired a spin off series, Queen Charlotte, which [departs](#) more enthusiastically from the historical record. Otherwise, and excepting some pointed omissions, Bridgerton [hews](#) largely to history. The [balls](#) really were this extravagant, and the sex was potentially just as hot. (The sources for this: delightful 18th-century erotica.) Even Queen Charlotte’s [swan wig](#) has a precedent. Still, there are dozens of [online threads](#) devoted to the ways in which Bridgerton diverges from the real Regency — the hairstyles, the fashions, the smoking. And there are more substantive online arguments, discussions about what it means to diversify the aristocracy retrospectively without a consideration of the real-world racism and colonialism of the time. The show also ignores the political changes taking place elsewhere (the Napoleonic Wars are [barely](#) mentioned) and the changes [wrought](#) by the Industrial Revolution at home. “That would be a very, very different show,” Vickery said. “That’s just not what Bridgerton is trying to do. It’s really about female pleasure. Probably Bridgerton thinks more about female pleasure than a lot of aristocratic men did.” Vickery and Greig say that, as viewers, they never experience the discomfort of an apparent anachronism. Mostly because they know to expect it. And they believe that deliberate anachronisms can [spark](#) productive conversations among historians and [laypeople](#) both. “We are asked many more questions now about what is the real history of race, what is the real history of a relationship between England and South Asia,” Greig said. “It actually opens up the conversation in a way that other [period dramas](#) might not.” Vickery said that consulting on the show has enriched her work as a historian. The questions of fashion and etiquette that the writers ask often [border](#) issues of power, reputation and risk. And she described her visits to the set in vivid terms. “It’s [astounding](#),” Vickery said. “It’s like seeing an army in the field. But you’re then asked if you’ve any notes.” Often they do and often those notes are then incorporated, a gift to any academic. “Bridgerton is an absolute joy,” Greig said. “It’s a fiction. It’s a fantasy. It’s a way of asking ourselves to think differently about the past, and that’s one of its great pleasures.” Published in The New York Times on 13 June 2024. Reprinted with permission.

Glossary

- **online threads** = discussioni online
- **enflowered** = fiorito
- **swoon** = andare in estasi
- **speech** = battute, discorso
- **posited** = ipotizzare
- **border** = affiancare
- **on-call geek** = esperto reperibile
- **depart** = allontanarsi
- **tidbits** = curiosità
- **evening out the scales** = riequilibrare le cose
- **spark** = innescare
- **astounding** = sorprendente
- **cast** = avere nel cast
- **compliment** = complimento
- **Regency-ify** = adattare allo stile dell'età della Reggenza
- **schoolmistress** = maestra
- **balls** = balli
- **barely** = a malapena
- **wrought** = provocare, infliggere
- **motto of sorts** = una sorta di motto
- **dull** = noiosa
- **hot air balloons** = mongolfiere
- **showrunner** = produttrice creativa
- **swan wig** = parrucca a forma di cigno
- **laypeople** = non esperti, profani
- **grounded** = basarsi
- **telling them off** = rimproverare
- **period dramas** = drammi in costume
- **absolute letter** = cronaca letterale
- **spanning** = estendersi, coprire
- **widow** = vedova
- **plot hole** = buco di trama
- **echelons** = ranghi
- **Thank goodness** = grazie al cielo
- **repurposes** = dare una nuova funzione
- **knowingly** = consapevolmente
- **conterminous** = che coincide
- **erasure** = cancellazione
- **hews** = attenersi